Housing landscape map

Description

This map shows the different types of buildings that people live in. It includes typical residential buildings like houses where the vast majority of people live. It also includes buildings that might be designed to provide temporary or short-term accommodation, buildings constructed using non-standard methods, prisons, and buildings where residents are provided with support or healthcare.

The government departments responsible for these buildings vary depending on their use. We created this map as a tool to consider people's different housing experiences beyond these boundaries. Where you or those you know have lived can impact your behaviours and expectations around current home, and some regulations can apply across these different buildings.

The data included is from publicly available sources as of February 2025 and is for England only unless specified.

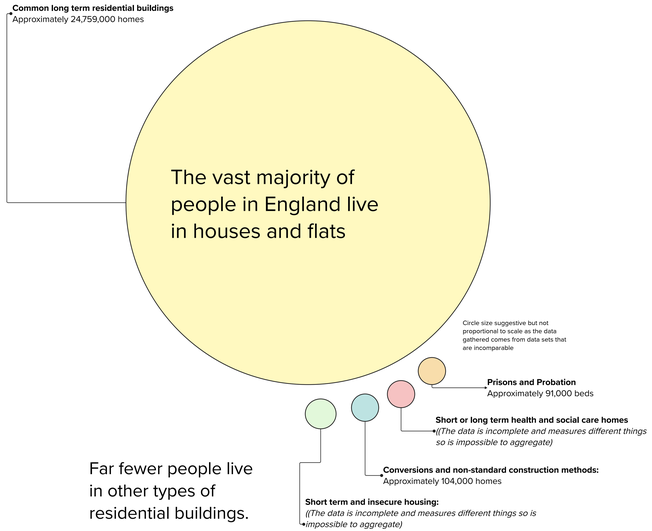
We were unable to find complete and reliable data for several building types outside of common long-term residential buildings, this impacts how we understand the scale of issues. For example, we heard from Environmental Health professionals some caravans are in poor condition and can be difficult to regulate and enforce safety in. But there is limited data about how many people live in caravans long term or how many may be rented as homes, so it's hard to know how many people might be impacted.

How to use this map

Read through the map to find out about different types of residential buildings. When possible, we have given the number of buildings of this type in England. For communal establishments, we have tried to include the number of beds or the number of people that live in these buildings.

Share your feedback

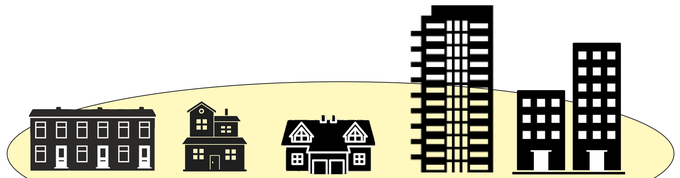
If you would like further information or have any feedback or ideas for improvements, please email us at SystemDesignTeam@communities.gov.uk



Common long-term residential buildings

These categories are about what type of common residential buildings there are in England. The vast majority of people in England live in a type of building in this category.

Each of these categories includes buildings that can be of any ownership type, including leasehold properties with a freeholder, freehold properties, and shared ownership. The residents in these buildings might have any of the different types of tenancy, including owner-occupied, private tenancy, social tenancy, and a tenancy in a HMO (either private or social). These buildings might be used as temporary accommodation.



Terraced houses

Number of dwellings: 9,684,649[1]

A whole house or bungalow that is in a terrace, including end terraces.

The figures include shared buildings (where more than one household live in the building together) and empty buildings.

Data from the 2021 Census

Detached houses

Number of dwellings: 5,393,995[1]

A whole house or bungalow that is detached.

The figures include shared buildings (where more than one household live in the building together) and empty buildings

Data from the 2021 Census

Semi-detached houses

Number of dwellings: 7,918,210[1]

A whole house or bungalow that is semi-detached.

The figures include shared buildings (where more than one household live in the building together) and empty buildings

Data from the 2021 Census

Flats (over 18m)

Number of buildings: ~12,500[2]
Number of residents: ~1,300,000[2]

Flats (7m - 18m)

Number of buildings: ~75,000[2]

Low-rise flats (2 - 5 storeys)

Number of flats: ~3,787,000[3]

[1] Dwellings figures, 2021, MHCLG
[2] Heavy lifts and Engineers Journal, March 2022
[3] Estimate

Flats

Total number of flats: 5,992,000[1]
Number of purpose built flats: 4,417,000[1]
Number of flats in converted houses/ buildings: 1,177,000[1]
Number of flats in commercial building: 247,000[1]

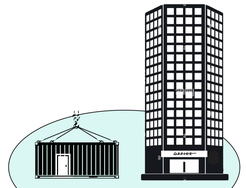
This data includes shared flats (where more than one household live in the flat together) and empty flats.

No of 2020. Census data

Conversions and non-standard construction methods.

This category includes residential buildings that are converted from other commercial uses and buildings made with non-standard construction methods. This includes things like pre-fab homes, modular homes, and container homes.

Both of these categories includes buildings that can be of any ownership type, including leasehold properties with a freeholder, freehold properties, and shared ownership. The residents in these buildings might have any of the different types of tenancy, including owner-occupied, private tenancy, social tenancy, and a tenancy in a HMO (either private or social). These buildings might be used as temporary accommodation.



Pre-fab, modular and container homes

Number of pre-fab homes: ~6,000[1]

Prefabricated houses, known as 'prefabs', were an interim solution after WW2 until the country could return to constructing permanent homes with traditional building materials. They were intended to last no more than a decade.

Container homes are homes built by converting shipping containers. Some have been built and used by local authorities as temporary accommodation, it is unclear how many of these there are in England.

Modular homes are built offsite, including kitchens, bathrooms, and stairs. They are then assembled at the location to create a building. We could not find data about how many modular homes there are in England.

No of 2020, according to the Pre-Fab Institute

Office to Housing Conversion

Number of conversions since 2016: 95,964[1]

Office to residential conversions were introduced as permitted development rights as long as the freeholder meets specific regulations. This means that these conversions do not require planning permission.

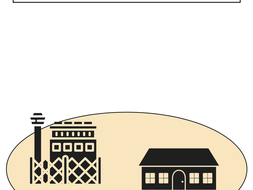
No of 2024 rate since 2016. Data from gov.uk

Prisons and Probation

This category includes buildings that house people awaiting trials or sentencing, offenders or offenders who have been released from prison on license.

Some of these people will be locked into cells at various points in the day. Building safety is critical for these residents as they will be unable to escape on their own. There were over 2200 prison cell fires in England and Wales in 2023 (NAO), increasing the capacity of the prison estate to meet demand, 2024).

These buildings are operated, maintained and inspected by other government departments, including HM Prison and Probation Service, HM Inspectorate of Probation and HM Inspectorate of Prisons.



Prisons

Number of prisoners: 85,618[1]
Number of prison places: 88,888[1]
Number of prisons: 122[1]

This data is for England and Wales.

Prisons are operated by HM Prison and Probation Service and regulated by HM Inspectorate of Prisons in the MoJ.

No of 30 Dec, 2024. Data from GMPM.uk.gov.uk

Approved Premises

Number of Approved Premises (APs): 100[1]
Number of beds in APs 2,360[1]

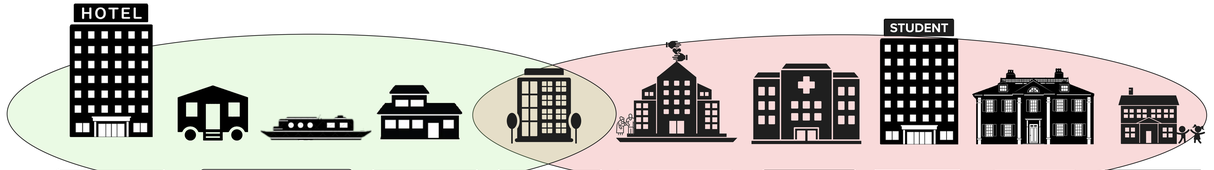
Approved premises are residential units which house ex-offenders in the community.

The majority of APs are operated by HM Prison and Probation Service. Some APs are not inspected by any regulator. HM Inspectorate of Probation is currently initiating an inspection programme for APs that would include how the buildings are maintained.

No of May 2024, report from HM Inspectorate of Prisons
[1] Data from same report but covers England and Wales

Short term and insecure housing

These are buildings which are used as short-term accommodation or are residential buildings with less secure tenancies. It is not expected that people spend long living in these buildings/dwellings but many people do. Residents in these buildings often have less secure tenancies and might struggle to access some services. Some residents in these buildings might not have access to amenities, like kitchens, and laundry.



Hotels

Number of people claiming asylum living in hotels: 25,637[1]

Number of homeless households living in B&Bs and hotels: 18,390[2]

We are only interested in people staying in hotels for a significant period of time as a form of temporary accommodation. This number has risen over the pandemic, 18,390 households in temporary accommodation, 10,360 were living in hotels and the rest in B&B's, compared to June 2024, up 30.5% from the same time last year[2].

People who live in hotels often don't have access to cooking or laundry facilities, and families have to share one room. They have little space and can be moved on at short notice when the hotel needs the rooms back.

No of 2024, Refugee Council
No of Dec 2024, MHCLG Statutory Homeless data

Caravans, boats and other mobile or temporary structures

Number of occupied caravans, boats, mobile structures or temporary structures (including Gypsy and Traveller and boats): 99,899[1]
Number of Traveller caravans: 12,765[2]
Number of Traveller pitches: 26,622[2]

The number of people living in homes in this section has increased by 15,000 since the 2011 census. We do not know how many people live in each type of mobile structure.

A static caravan, also called a park home or mobile home, must be able to be moved in one piece and by law, the vast majority of people live in static caravans. We do know the number of Traveller caravans.

Not everyone who lives on a boat has a mooring. Many boaters have 'continuous cruising licenses'. The conditions of these licenses mean they must keep moving and not stay in one place. They might struggle to access services and do not have a fixed address.

Data from the 2021 Census
[1] The total number of caravans or other mobile or temporary structures. This is a count of units, not people. The figure includes 99,296 caravans, 403 boats and 200 other structures. A survey of travellers which suggested that 36.2% of travellers lived already living in bricks and mortar accommodation, 30.4% lived on sites owned by the local authority, 19.3% on sites owned by travellers, etc. We do not know the proportion of temporary/permanent. In the last Rough Sleeping Snapshot, 1,104 people were recorded as rough sleeping who identified as Gypsy, Roma or Traveller.
[2] Data from the 2021 Census

Homeless Shelters

Number of people living in hostels and homeless shelters: 13,855[1]

Number of accommodation projects for homeless people: 907[1]

Number of day centres: 168[1]

When homeless people in England are housed, it is often in a hostel or shelter. We include temporary lights. This section covers emergency, short term accommodation

There is likely to be some significant overlap between this section and the supported housing section.

Data from the 2021 Census
[1]Gap Data Homeless List 2023-2024(the latest available data)

Supported Housing

Number of social sector supported housing units: 509,873[1]
Number of units for older people: 349,300[1]
Number of units for short term or transitional housing: 17,600[1]
Number of long term supported units for working age people with disabilities 74,400[1]

Supported housing has been defined as accommodation which is provided alongside care, support or supervision to help people with their tenancy, which is not otherwise provide in the community. The figures here are dwellings or units within the social rent or affordable rent sector. We cannot find data that tells us how many units there are in the private sector.

Housing units in this section might also be counted in the "homeless shelter" section.

Data from the 2021 Census
[1] Data from the 2021 Census

Residential Care Homes and Nursing Homes

Number of Registered Care Homes: 10,018[1]
Number of people living in Care Homes: 153,470[1]
Number of Nursing Homes: 600[2]
Number of people living in Nursing Homes: 51,450[1]

A care home is supported accommodation that provides support with personal care, like dressing and washing, as well as opportunities for activities and socialising. Nursing homes provide additional nursing care for those residents who need higher levels of care, whether that is immediate care following being discharged from a hospital or a long-term care need.

Both care homes and nursing homes can be independent or state-funded. Both types provide support for a range of needs, including old age, learning disabilities and memory disorders.

No of Dec 2024, Care Quality Commission (CQC)
[1] As of March 2023, ONS. Adult Social Care Report
[2] As of March 2023, ONS. Adult Social Care Report

Short or long term health and social care

These buildings are the buildings where people live or stay long term and are supported in their needs. This could be because the residents are children, or require health or social care.

Residents might share a room, have their own room, or their own self-contained flat or house within a building or complex.

These buildings might be regulated by legislation that is owned by other government departments, like the Department for Education and Department for Health and Social Care.

Residential healthcare settings

Number of people in general hospitals: 99,9[1]
Number of people in mental health hospitals for 6 months: 10,610[1]
Number of people in other hospitals for 6 months: 1,395[1]

These are units or wards where patients are expected to stay for long periods of time.

This could include places like rehabilitation facilities for serious injuries, addiction, eating disorders and mental health support.

Data from the 2021 Census

Student Accomodation

Number of people living in private built accomodation 200,990[1]

Number of people living in university-maintained halls 347,680[1]

This data is for purpose built student accommodation. We could not find data that's first data for England specifically. Many students in the UK live in HMO's in the private rented sector.

Data from 2021/22 academic year. Data from Cushman and

Boarding Schools and other Residential Schools

Number of schools: 640[1]
Boarding Schools 600[1]
Residential Accommodation 40[1]
Residential Special Schools 160[1]

These buildings are schools with a residential setting. They can be boarding schools or special schools. These can be state-funded but the majority are independent.

No of Dec 2024. Data from DfE Get Info Schools School

Children's Homes

Number of children's homes: 2499[1]
Number of children in children's homes 14,340[1]
Number of residential schools: 104[1]

A children's home is an establishment that provides care and accommodation for children. Children's homes vary in size and nature. They fulfil a range of purposes designed to meet the different needs of those children who are looked after and those assessed as needing a residential care placement. Some homes, for example, provide short breaks, which are needed to help support children and their family. Some residential schools provide children's residential children's homes because boarders are resident for more than 295 days per year.

No of Jan 2025. Data from Ofsted reports and Children's social care